

Help the Great Barrier Reef

The Reef is alive, but it is under pressure. What facts can help us explain why it needs protection?

READING MISSION

Underline two facts. Circle one action. Box the sentence that stops an overclaim.

1 A huge living place

The Great Barrier Reef is not one wall of coral. It is a huge living system along the Queensland coast. It has about 3,000 reefs, as well as islands, seagrass, mangroves and deep water. Fish, turtles and many other animals live there.

The Reef is also Sea Country. Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Traditional Owners have cared for this area for a very long time. Today, Traditional Owners use cultural knowledge and science to help care for the Reef.

2 What scientists found

Scientists check the Reef to see how it changes. In 2024-25, they checked 124 reefs. They still found living coral in the north, centre and south, but coral cover had fallen. Hot water and other pressures had damaged coral.

This is evidence that the Reef is alive and needs help. It is not evidence that the whole Reef is dead.

Coral animals live with tiny algae that give them food and colour. Very warm water can make coral push out the algae and turn white. This is called **bleaching**.

Bleached coral is stressed, but it is not always dead. Some coral can recover if the water cools. Coral can die if the heat is very strong, lasts too long or returns before the coral has recovered.

3 Two ways to help

Help near the Reef

Cleaner water, less rubbish, careful fishing, crown-of-thorns starfish control and Sea Country management can reduce pressure. These local actions can give coral a better chance to recover.

Reduce ocean warming

Greenhouse gases warm Earth and the ocean. Climate action can reduce this warming. Local projects help, but they cannot cool the whole ocean by themselves.

A strong plan uses both kinds of action: help the Reef now and reduce the warming pressure for the future.

Word help

evidence - a fact that helps prove an idea

coral cover - how much of an area is covered by living hard coral

recover - become healthier again

local - in or near a place